

The Third Battle of Winchester was a bloody, daylong fight that surged back and forth across rolling fields. Though they repulsed a number of Union assaults, the Confederates finally broke when cavalry attacked their flanks. Having suffered nearly 40 percent casualties, Early's troops streamed back through the streets of Winchester and entrenched on Fisher's Hill, 15 miles (24km) to the south.

Three days later, at sunset on September 22, Sheridan attacked at Fisher's Hill. The Union soldiers scrambled over rocks, walls, and felled trees with their commander urging them on: "Forward! Forward everything! Go on, don't stop, go on!" Outflanked again, Early's men abandoned their positions, losing more than 1,000, and were chased deep into the night by their relentless foe.

Utter devastation

Sheridan next turned his attention to the surrounding landscape, whose crops had been supplying the Confederate army. Grant had ordered him to "turn the valley into such a barren waste that even a crow flying over it would have to carry his own rations." As the torches were handed out, his soldiers began igniting the many fires that, taken together, would always be remembered by residents as "The Burning." Far and wide, immense pillars of smoke arose as every barn, stable, mill, haystack, and supply of forage went up in flames. Some 2,000 barns and 120 mills with their stocks of grain and flour were consumed by fire. Countless fences, wagons, and farming implements were destroyed. Livestock was run off. Hundreds of square miles of once-beautiful farmland were wrecked and scorched. There was little that the Confederacy could do about it. Partisan activities by cavalry commander John Mosby's group and others only brought reprisals. When Early's cavalry pressed too close, it was driven off at the Battle of Tom's Brook on October 9. George Armstrong Custer's jeering horsemen nicknamed the galloping stampede the "Woodstock Races" as the Confederates retreated for more than 20 miles (32km).